

Malcolm Dupuis

Professor Benjelloun

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Visual Rhetorical Analysis

Introduction

When people consider what literature is, they often fail to consider unconventional everyday media. Rather than essays, theses, and research, we are often surrounded by what may be considered “lesser.” Melanie Gagich argues that “A text is a movie, meme, social media post, essay, website, podcast, and the list goes on.” (Gagich 66). This further supports that our lives are heavily influenced by the media artifacts we consume every day, even when they are not initially viewed as writing. Movie posters, book covers, campaign flyers, advertisements, and social media posts all communicate messages through words, images, color, layout, and symbolism. Jean Kilbourne’s *Killing Us Softly 4: Advertising’s Image of Women*, Pulp Fiction’s movie release poster, politician James Fishback’s campaign ads, and Art Spiegelman’s controversial *Maus II: A Survivor’s Tale: And Here My Troubles Began* book cover all serve as prime examples as to how text can be hidden in common media. As these texts shape how audiences understand identity, language, literacy, and power, they deserve the same level of rhetorical analysis as more traditional academic writing.

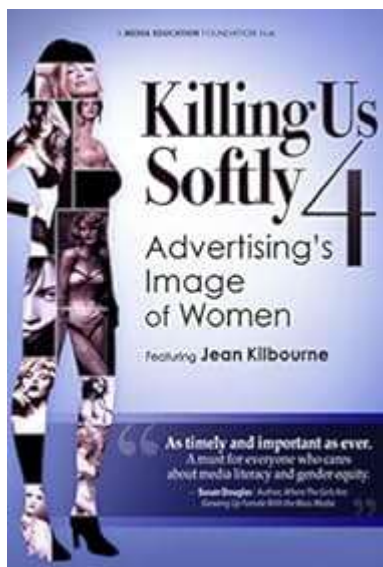
Rhetorical elements, such as situation, appeals, and elements like figurative language all help to build the diverse literary environment that surrounds audiences everywhere. Laura Bollin Carroll explains in her essay *Backpacks vs. Briefcases: Steps toward Rhetorical Analysis* that

“Rhetoric—the way we use language and images to persuade—is what makes media work.”

(Carroll 46). This further pushes the idea the all media devices are built primarily through rhetoric. For instance, a poster does not merely advertise a movie, but rather utilizes wording, imagery, and layout to influence how the audience feels. By studying these choices, rhetorical analysis reveals how everyday text shapes our views on identity, literacy, and influence.

Jean Kilbourne, *Killing us Softly 4: Advertising's Image of Women*

Figure 1: Cover for *Killing us Softly 4: Advertising's Image of Women*, depicts silhouette made of women's media



Jean Kilbourne's *Killing us Softly 4: Advertising's Image of Women* is a film documentary critiquing how gender stereotypes are pushed onto women by the modern advertising industry. It covers ideas such as misogyny, body image, and sexual objectification of women. The film is a prime example of how visual rhetoric can shape how audiences view identity and power in our culture. Kilbourne brings into discussion the fact that advertisements do not simply sell products; they sell ideas about beauty, self-worth, and sexuality. The film often depicts women being

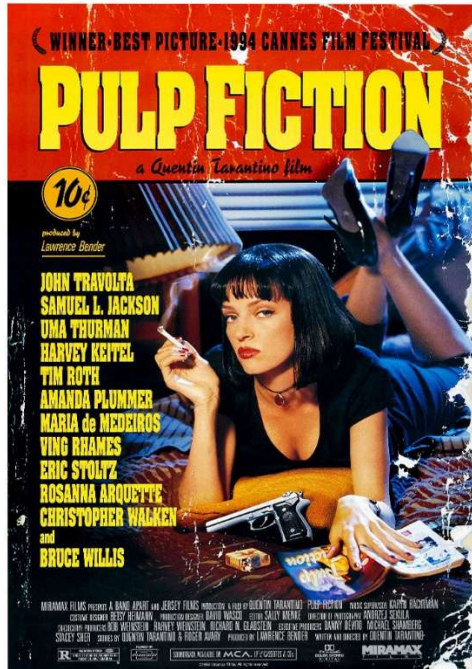
edited, cropped to body parts, or wearing revealing clothing to express the standard advertisements push onto women. Kilbourne uses rhetorical and visual appeals to persuade audiences without making a direct argument.

Kilbourne's film analysis also pertains to ENC 11011's Writing and Power Learning Outcome as it shows how media depicts ideas such as identity, literacy, language, and power. Keith Grant-Davie explains that "rhetorical discourse comes into existence as a response to situation." (Grant-Davie 265). This is exhibited in the film as it discusses the author's observed concerns regarding patterns in women's advertising. In order to dissect an advertisement, viewers must be able to "read" its visual rhetoric. For instance, the movie uses specific design choices in its advertisements through poses, angles, and slogans to exhibit women as passive. This type of advertising holds power as it pushes harmful ideals into modern culture, influencing people's self-identity.

Similarly to the film, many seemingly "less significant" artifacts, such as book titles, movie posters, and campaign ads use specific design choices to influence the audience. For instance, a movie poster could use body language and color to create an air of mystery surrounding the film, or a book cover could use strong symbolism to represent historic events. Kilbourne's film reveals that media is always pushing an idea. Shaping what audiences see as important or desirable, images participate in a system of power that influences how people understand the world around them. This is why visual rhetoric matters as it teaches audiences to look beyond surface images and question the purpose behind media.

Quentin Tarantino, *Pulp Fiction*

Figure 2: *Pulp Fiction* movie release poster, depicts woman smoking and lists cast



The first artifact that demonstrates visual rhetoric is the movie poster for *Pulp Fiction*. Showing a woman surrounded by contraband and utilizing bright colors, the poster builds an identity for the movie beyond just being a crime film. The poster uses the style of an old pulp magazine cover, with a edges and yellow title, the dramatic imagery of the woman in bed, and the numerous props such as the gun to create an atmosphere of danger. The audience is not only being told of the films name, but rather being immersed in its world of mystery, violence, and rebellion. This connects to Melanie Gagich’s idea that texts are not limited to essays or books, since movie posters also communicate through visual and linguistic rhetoric.

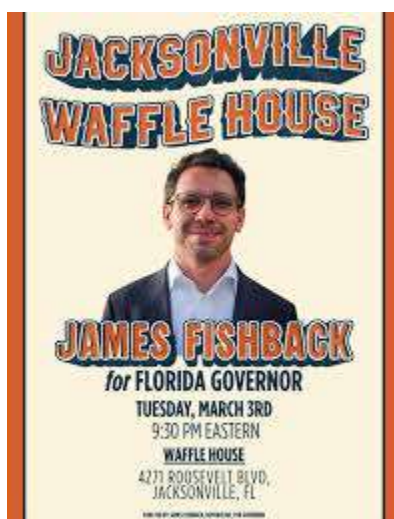
The poster’s rhetorical situation also helps to establish why it is so persuasive. As Grant-Davie explains, rhetorical situations are shaped by “exigence, rhetors, audiences, and constraints.” (Grant-Davie 266). The exigence of the film’s poster is the need to attract an audience for the movie by quickly communicating its genre and attitude. Its intended audience is likely viewers interested in crime, rebellion, and Tarantino’s unconventional style of storytelling.

The film heavily utilizes rhetoric appeals through multiple major design choices. The visual design builds pathos by depicting the film as bold and artistic through dark imagery, while its casting and director establish ethos for the film. Even the title itself, *Pulp Fiction*, connects the film to the stories of classic cheap crime magazines. In this way, the poster ties in both images and language to establish an identity for the film without revealing the plot.

The *Pulp Fiction* poster also connects with writing and power as it shows how visual language constructs identity in media. The woman on the poster is posed in a way that depicts her as dangerous, confident, and mysterious. This depiction further pushes the overall message for the movie. Like the advertisements Jean Kilbourne analyzes in *Killing Us Softly 4*, the poster uses a woman's body, facial expression, and pose as part of its persuasive message. This does not directly correlate the poster to the ideas discussed by Kilbourne, but it does show how visual media establishes meaning through bodies and imagery. The audience must be visually literate enough to recognize how the image is shaping ideas about gender, danger, desire, and power.

James Fishback, Campaign Ads

Figure 3: Campaign ad for Florida governor candidate James Fishback



The second artifact, James Fishback's campaign ad at a Jacksonville Waffle House, utilizes an entirely different style of rhetoric. Unlike the *Pulp Fiction* poster, which serves to establish the film's theme and style, the campaign ad tries to build credibility and trust. The setting of the Waffle House is critical as the unconventional setting builds a sense of familiarity and being casual outside the world of elite politics. By placing the campaign's message in this environment, Fishback is saying that he connects with ordinary Floridians. Brandt's argument that "Sponsors nevertheless set the terms for access to literacy" applies to the James Fishback campaign advertisement as voters must be able to interpret campaigns in order to make educated decisions on candidates (Brandt 166). The ad frames Fishback as a qualified but down-to-earth candidate through a familiar Waffle House setting, patriotic colors, and campaign language.

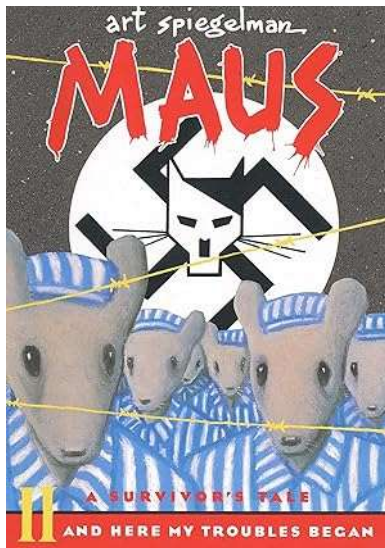
His campaign artifact uses ethos as its strongest appeal as political advertisements must establish the candidate's credibility and qualifications. The Waffle House setting creates this credibility by making Fishback seem grounded in everyday life. Similarly, the artifact utilizes pathos by appealing to comfort, familiarity, and local identity. The audience is pushed to view the candidate as someone who understands regular people and local spaces rather than a disconnected political figurehead. Carroll's explanation that media asks audiences to "believe something to be true" applies here because the campaign image is asking voters to believe Fishback is a quality candidate for governor (Carroll 46).

The Fishback advertisement also reveals a strong connection between language, literacy, and power. Campaigns heavily rely on their audience's perception of visual and linguistic cues. Brandt's idea of literary sponsorship is useful here as political campaigns intend to teach audiences how to read a candidate's identity. The campaign becomes a sponsor in a way as it shows voters the framework for authority, who belongs in leadership, and how political power

should be distributed. However, this also eliminates neutrality in political campaigns as they are carefully constructed to establish popular belief and behavior.

Art Spiegelman, *Maus II: “A Survivor’s Tale: And Here My Troubles Began”*

Figure 4: Book cover for *Maus II: “A Survivor’s Tale: And Here My Troubles Began”*, depicts prisoner mice with nazi swastika symbol in background



The third artifact, the cover of *Maus II: “A Survivor’s Tale: And Here My Troubles Began”*, uses visual rhetoric in a more serious way with intense historical significance, causing it to be banned across a multitude of school districts. Unlike the *Pulp Fiction* movie poster or James Fishback’s campaign ad, *Maus II* memorializes the memory of the trauma and survival of the Holocaust. The cover’s imagery is powerful as Spiegelman represents the Jewish people as mice and Nazis as cats, using animal symbolism to communicate the violence and oppression of the Holocaust. The choice initially seems simple but is in fact deeply complex when considering the historical context of the book. The image does more than just introduce the title as it builds elements of identity, persecution, and survival.

The rhetorical situation of *Maus II* cover is shaped by its purpose as both modern literature and a testimony to history. Its audience may include scholars, general readers, and historians as well as those who read graphic novels. The cover must persuade readers that the book is serious and meaningful, even though it uses a comic-style visual form. This creates a tension as people often assume comics are less serious than traditional books, but *Maus II* challenges this. Gagich's definition of text helps explain why this matters as she explains that text "is a piece of communication that can take many forms" (Gagich 66). If texts can include visual and multimodal forms, then a graphic novel can be analyzed as seriously as an essay or formal report.

Maus II connects especially strongly to the Writing and Power learning outcome because it shows how literacy can preserve memory and challenge oppression. Spiegelman uses the animal visual language to represent the power system within the Holocaust, taking into account that Nazi ideology reduced humans to categories. The symbolism of the cover forces the reader to confront ideas on how identity is shaped and controlled by political power. At the same time, the book represents the resistance of the Jewish community to oppression as it tells a survivor's story through both words and meaningful imagery. When taking into account Brandt's discussion of access to literacy, literacy goes beyond just school as it decides who tells history and how stories are preserved.

Conclusion

These artifacts also show why rhetorical analysis is necessary. As Carroll explains, media constantly asks audiences to buy, believe, act, or interact in certain ways. Because of this, audiences must inherently be able to critically examine media rather than just allowing themselves to be easily influenced. Kilbourne's *Killing Us Softly 4* demonstrates this same point,

showing how patterns in advertising have adverse effects on cultural ideas on identity, beauty, and power. In the same way, movie posters, campaign ads, and book covers use visual rhetoric to shape ideas about identity, credibility, history, and value.

The *Pulp Fiction* poster establishes style through color, poses, and genre references, while the James Fishback campaign advertisement uses setting and local identity to build trust and political credibility. In contrast, *Maus II* uses symbolism and historical context to represent trauma, identity, and survival. Together, these artifacts show that visual rhetor exists across all forms of media, including entertainment, politics, and historical literature. Although these artifacts differ in audience and purpose, they each support the idea that images and words work together in literature to shape how audiences think and feel.

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